Cell Biology of Extracellular Matrix

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Preface

At a recent meeting to discuss the domains of cell biology, I put forth a case for the extracellular matrix, even though my argument ran the risk of falling on deaf ears. After all, the matrix is EXTRAcellular, outside the cells. In this book, however, the authors make a compelling case for the relevance of the matrix to cellular concerns. Not only are numerous cell types, including many epithelia, quite caught up in the business of manufacturing matrix components, but also most of them contain matrix molecules in exoskeletons that are attached to the plasmalemma and that organize or otherwise influence the affairs of the cytoplasm. The idea of this book is to present the extracellular matrix to cell biologists of all levels. The authors are active and busy investigators, recognized experts in their fields, but all were enthusiastic about the prospect of writing for this audience. The chapters are not "review" articles in the usual sense, nor are they rehashes of symposium talks; they were written specifically for this book and they present the "state of the art" in engaging style, with ample references to more technical or historical reviews. The book is rich in electron micrographs and diagrams and for many of the latter, as well as for the design of the cover, we are indebted to Sylvia J. Keene, medical illustrator for the Department of Anatomy at Harvard Medical School. We also owe special thanks to Susan G. Hunt of this Department, who did a masterful preliminary job of editing the manuscripts, and to the editors and staff of Plenum Press, who were supporting and helpful throughout the enterprise. We think you will enjoy this treatise.

Elizabeth D. Hay

Contents

Chapter 3
Elastin

Carl Franzblau and Barbara Faris

Chapter 4
Fibronectin and Other Structural Proteins

Kenneth M. Yamada

PART II. HOW DO CELLS PRODUCE THE MATRIX?

Chapter 5
Proteoglycan Biosynthesis

Albert Dorfman

Chapter 6
Collagen Biosynthesis

Bjorn Reino Olsen

Chapter 7
Matrix Assembly

Robert L. Trelstad and Frederick H. Silver

Chapter 8
An Essay on Biological Degradation of Collagen

Jerome Gross

PART III. WHAT DOES MATRIX DO FOR CELLS?

Chapter 9
Glycosaminoglycans in Morphogenesis

Bryan P. Toole

Chapter 10
Fibronectin and Its Relation to Cellular Structure and Behavior

Richard O. Hynes

Chapter 11
The Glomerular Basement Membrane: A Selective Macromolecular Filter

Marilyn Gist Farquhar

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